Epilogue

The helicopter door closed and we lifted off. Without telling us he was going to do it, the pilot made a turn and circled the Capitol. Beneath us was the spectacular panorama that had been our neighborhood: the Washington Monument, the Lincoln and Jefferson memorials, and now the bands and floats of the inaugural parade—and, everywhere on this day, huge crowds. Everything pointed to the marvel of our system of government and the ease with which it exercised the peaceful transition of power.

But then the pilot reduced the circle and took us lower. We were circling the White House. There it was, complete with its sweep of green lawn and sparkling fountains. I said: “Look, honey, there’s our little shack.”

I find it hard to describe my feeling. It was entirely different from the way it was back in those days when I’d looked on the building with such a feeling of awe. Now I was looking at what had been our home for eight years. We were familiar with every room and hallway and had the warmest memories of our life in that beautiful, historic mansion. Now we were saying good-bye. We kept looking back until it was out of sight. As we came in to Andrews for our landing we saw a large military detachment, an equally large civilian crowd, and a military band awaiting us. It was a farewell in which I reviewed the troops, then shook hands with each of them. The band played the National Anthem and we boarded the airplane that for eight years had been Air Force One.

Here again we were filled with memories. We had literally been around the world more than once in that plane and had covered our nation many times. As we stepped aboard for the last time, I noticed how much things seemed just the